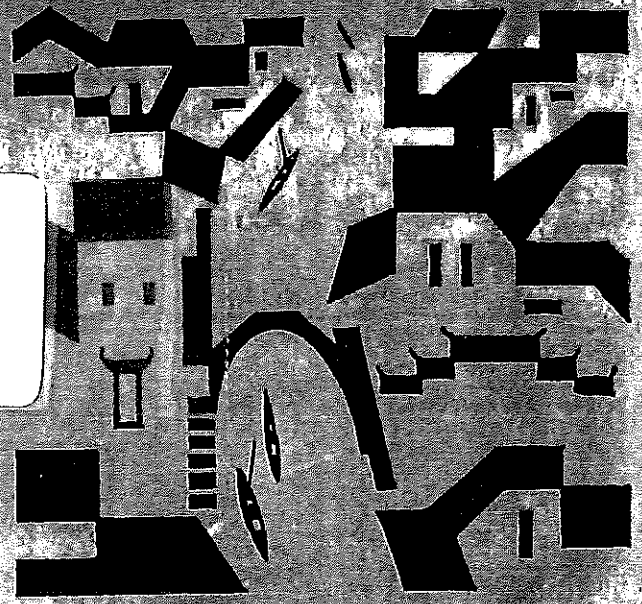
Mao Dun

The Vixen



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Except for "Recollections of Hainan", written in 1963, all the pieces in this collection of stories and essays by the celebrated Chinese novelist Mao Dun were written before the People's Republic of China was founded in 1949.

In 1932 Mao Dun returned to his home town from Japan, where he had lived since 1928, and witnessed on the way the poverty and want of the countryside under the rule of the KMT government. He depicted what he saw in four of his best short stories, of which "Spring Silkworms" and "The Shop of the Lin Family" are printed here.

The essays give voice to his indignation against the decadent regime, while his hope and confidence in the common Chinese people are fully expressed in the essay "In Praise of the White Poplar".

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Creation

THE small desk by the south window, spread with a dark green cloth, had on its right corner a light blue porcelain vase from which leaned two half-open red roses, like mischievous girls laughing disdainfully at a pile of hard-bound books sitting bolt-upright in the opposite corner, their moralistic appearance making you believe that they definitely were not romances. A silver-plated ink box lay in the upper middle of the desk, well matched by the clean blotter with an old letter stuck in one corner of its leather frame. Another small desk stood under the west window. The crumpled magazines scattered over it had knocked over a triangular green glass thermometer. The nib of the golden fountain pen was kissing the white forehead of a girl on an art postcard. A big drop of ink had congealed on the nib like a black tear lamenting the pen cap's disappearance. A finely carved ivory rabbit, its pink eyes aslant, gazed reproachfully at a small paper fan lying open beside it, because the rude, pushing fan had toppled it. Now it lay there sulkily, revealing the fine green inscription on its white belly: "In memory of Xianxian's twenty-fourth birthday. From her loving husband Junshi." But the character "husband" appeared to have been scraped with a knife.

A sofa with a golden silk cover under the central window in the east wall was flanked by matching arm-

chairs like bodyguards. To the left, against the wall, stood a cabinet with two shelves, the top narrower one with two glass doors backed with purple silk. Opposite this cabinet, to the right of the right armchair, was a clothes rack for raincoats, capes, hats and the like. Beyond this was the right window in the east wall, the small square table in front of it spread with a tea-service and a cigarette container. Farther on, in the corner, was a dressing-table and a small door which appeared to lead to the bathroom. Against the north wall stood a wardrobe with an oval mirror-door reflecting the big wooden bed below the window in the middle of the west wall, its gauze mosquito-net and the two people sleeping there. The bedroom door, at an oblique angle to the west of the wardrobe, was tightly closed.

A woman's clothes lay scattered over the sofa. A sky-blue satin gown, black silk sleeveless jacket, white knitted bodice and pink panties with elastic at the legs and waist. These were bundled together as if waiting to be laundered, showing how hastily their mistress had undressed. From under the sofa protruded the polished tip of a girl's grey leather shoe; but its mate was hiding far off under the short-legged dressing-table: she would have to hunt for it. Right of the bed, near the door, was a stand for an imposing reading-lamp with an amber silk shade. Beside this were a dainty handkerchief embroidered in one corner, perfumed paper, powder-paper, a pocket-mirror, used tram tickets, small silver coins, receipts from a department store, a tiny engagement diary with a gold-embossed leather cover, a brooch and small visiting-cards — and the little things found in a young lady's handbag. An open magazine propped against the reading-lamp had pushed its shade

askew and stood there incongruously. On the lamp's bronze base a couple of little doves with outstretched wings had craned their heads as if to guess at the title on the cover: *Women and Politics.*

Sunlight shone through the gauze curtains of the east window, dappling the cream-painted furniture with gold. Suddenly the discordant roar of a fast car sounded down below, waking up one of the sleepers. As he opened his drowsy eyes and stirred, a strong scent assailed his nostrils. Instinctively turning his head he saw his wife still sleeping, her cheeks red as roses. Her bedding kicked off, she was lying on one side wearing only a long woollen vest which reached to her knees. So her arms and legs were exposed to the morning air, and the sunshine filtering through the gauze fell on her white limbs like dancing drops of water.

— If the sun had reached the bed it must be late.

As Junshi thought this, he yawned. He had turned in very early and had no idea when his wife had come home; but he still felt exhausted after waking up at three and being unable to get back to sleep, not dozing off until light glimmered in the window. Then, only half asleep, he had dreamed many short disconnected dreams. He could still remember most of one which struck him as ill-omened. He shut his eyes again to think over that dream, at the same time lightly taking his wife's hand.

Dreams, some say they reproduce the cares of the day, others that they are a subconscious activity; but Junshi believed neither theory. He claimed not to have dreamed since the age of fifteen. His wife doubted this.

"You must dream," she often said. "Most likely after waking up your dreams vanish."

"You're the dreamer," he would retort. "You not only dream in your sleep but with your eyes open."

Now to his surprise he had dreamed, confirming that in the past he hadn't had dreams — he hadn't forgotten them. So he tried to remember these dreams to tell his wife. He wouldn't lightly pass over even such little things, or let his wife suspect him of lying. He wanted at all times to be believed, looked up to and obeyed, to have her accept his love with her whole soul.

He breathed out light-heartedly and re-opened his eyes to stare at the sunlight dancing on the curtains. Then the bundle of clothes on the sofa caught his eye and he surveyed the whole room, his gaze finally coming to rest on his wife's face. For some reason though sound asleep she wore a faint frown and her lips were compressed, just as when she had quarrelled with him yesterday. Of late they had frequently fallen out. Xianxian often refuted him, and he criticized her behaviour even more often. Many of his criticisms seemed to her sheer contrariness. Her friend Miss Li thought this a sign of the progress Xianxian had made recently, whereas Junshi had regressed. Xianxian shared this view, but Junshi wouldn't admit this. At heart he resented Miss Li, thinking she had led his good wife completely astray. So yesterday he had found a pretext to let off steam and sharply disparaged Miss Li. What upset Xianxian most was his saying:

". . . Miss Li behaves just like a slick woman politician. She's busy every day with so-called political activities, but does she know the meaning of politics? I'm not against women taking an interest in politics, Xianxian, I used to encourage you to do that, so that now you have some idea what's involved. But you must be realistic — ha! You lack the subjective ability, and the objective conditions aren't ripe. Besides, Miss Li is just looking upon political activities as films or dances which are simply fashionable pastimes for modern young women. She says women must be independent, must have social status — that's only show talk! In what way is Miss Li independent? What social status has she? I know. Her place, her status is dancing in the Carlton or Moon Palace. Now she's dissatisfied with the status quo and wants to make revolution. Bah, revolution, it used to disgust her, but now she calls new stunts in cinemas or dance halls revolution. . . ."

What upset Xianxian most was Junshi's attitude — his conviction that no one else could ever amount to much. This was worse than his conservatism and his insinuations. She had really lost her temper. Though he had later tried to comfort her she had been in a tizzy for hours.

Watching his wife's expression as she slept, Junshi recalled the previous day's dispute. He felt Xianxian was daily becoming more estranged from him, that he could no longer monopolize her heart and soul. She had broken away from his moral ascendancy to develop views of her own. This was hard for someone as opinionated as Junshi to take. He loved his wife, still loved her, but had loved most of all the wife who had modelled her thoughts and actions on his. Unfortunately that golden age had passed, she was no longer the Xianxian of two years ago.

Junshi could not help sighing over this. He closed his eyes again to consider how the change had come

about. He recalled that two years ago when they summered in Mt. Mogan, Xianxian had expressed an independent opinion about women's social duties — had that been the start of her present dissidence? It didn't seem likely, she hadn't met Miss Li then; yet it was possible, as since then she had steadily deteriorated. This last half year not only had her views changed, even her behaviour had lost its earlier charm, she tossed her clothes and things about at random as if too busy with important affairs to care for appearances. He instinctively opened his eyes to glance round the room and saw that his domain had shrunk to the desk below the south window. Apart from this neat enclave, the whole chaotic room was Xianxian's domain.

With a heavy heart Junshi went on to recall all Xianxian's disagreements with him over trifles. That holiday in Mt. Mogan when they were in complete accord had been the height of their happiness, yet even then a fateful black thread seemed to have entered their lives. Xianxian's metamorphosis had started, it seemed, with her taste, for by degrees she tired of quiet refinement and demanded strong stimuli, often disagreeing with him over everyday affairs. They would argue over what material to buy, what film to see, what restaurant to go to. They often opted for different things and were unwilling for each to go his or her way, both wanting their proposal to triumph completely. In the end one side was sacrificed. As both disliked the idea of each going his own way they felt it better to take it in turns to win, and of course the winner was very satisfied while the loser had the consolation of a sweet kiss asking for understanding. The first couple of disputes

like this really upset them, till they discovered the joy of reconciliation and tacitly accepted these tiffs as essential to their love. So having grown used to this Junshi often told Xianxian:

"This time you've won again. But my fair lady, my spoilt miss, don't imagine your victory's reasonable or lasting."

Then laughing softly Xianxian would nestle in his arms and give him a long kiss. That was the price of her victory, her thanks to her loving husband for giving way to her.

Before long, though, the magic of this lovers' banter wore off. When the kissing became a mechanical routine, the one kissed felt the other's lips were cold, her smile was artificial, and his heart throbbed with the anguish of defeat. The more so as Xianxian came to stick to her views and nearly always insisted on winning. So, reluctantly, each had to go his own way. This was one reason why Junshi's sphere of influence in their room was now reduced to his desk.

Gradually their views had diverged. This was a silent, painful struggle. Junshi had done his utmost, but in vain, to recover his monopoly of his wife's heart. For she had set up a firm barrier against him, and the new influence on her mind, gaining in strength every day, was ousting the old one. This last month Junshi had been conscious several times of his defeat. He realized that his ascendancy over his wife would soon be overthrown, and couldn't understand how he had won her heart and dominated her soul so easily two years ago yet now had lost it imperceptibly, with apparently no hope of recovery. Two years ago her heart had been like a sponge, absorbing all his ideas; now it was as

hard as iron and not all his ardour could melt it. "A woman's heart is a mystery," he often thought. He could only resort to satire, in the hope that its acidity would melt the iron in her heart. So Miss Li became his target. He had decided that the change in his wife was entirely due to Miss Li. Sometimes he felt satire inappropriate — feared it might estrange Xianxian even more. But he had no other way. "Ah, a woman's heart is a mystery!" he concluded with a sigh.

Junshi suddenly went into action. Threw off his blanket and rolled to the edge of the bed, forgetting that he was still holding his wife's hand. This woke Xianxian. When she had collected herself she moved closer to her husband and looked over his shoulder at his face.

He shut his eyes and made no move. He felt a soft arm over his chest. Felt his ears tickled by fine fluffy hair. Still he kept his eyes shut, not moving but concentrating his attention. Presently a warm body pressed down on him and he clearly heard the beat of another heart. Forced to open his eyes, he saw Xianxian propped up on her arms and staring at his face, like a cat watching a rat that was shamming dead. He couldn't but laugh.

"I knew you were just pretending to be asleep."

Xianxian smiled and, relaxing, fell into his arms. Feeling her vitality through the long vest he could hardly control himself. But it pained him to think that this soft warm breast, this lovely face with arched eyebrows, these beautiful eyes, entrancing cherry-red lips — this whole captivating woman belonged to him, definitely belonged to him; but hidden deep inside all this was a

heart which he could feel beating, and that couldn't count as his! He could be in contact with Xianxian's lovely form, but apart from that there was a formless Xianxian — her soul — with which he had lost contact. Was this what was called the tragedy of love? Did this mean the end of their love?

Unable to shake off his sense of isolation he reflected painfully, ignoring Xianxian's questioning look. Suddenly a hand covered his eyes, its slender fingers in the sun like transparent coral. The bracelet, three rows of seed-pearls, which clasped her soft wrist, was a souvenir of their summer in Mt. Mogan. A few days ago the thread had broken, and it had just been mended. Junshi softly removed her hand. The seed-pearls felt cold and slippery against his fingers. His heart missed a beat. Ah, that pearl bracelet! It recalled their lost happiness on Mt. Mogan. Bless that happiness now gone never to return!

Junshi eyed the seed-pearls for a while in frustration, then looked at Xianxian's face. She was watching him drowsily and pensively.

"Didn't you find our life in the past very happy?"

He spoke slowly as if he had chewed over every word.

"I'm very happy now."

Xianxian smiled as she answered and nestled up to him.

"Don't blurt out whatever comes into your head, Xianxian. Think carefully."

"Then the first year or half year of our marriage or, strictly speaking, the first month was happiest."

"Why?"

She smiled again, bewildered by this cross-examination.

"Why? No reason. Except that everything was a new experience for me. Before that my life had been a white sheet of paper, but then colour was added to it. Thinking back now to my girlhood, it wasn't specially interesting and I'm very hazy about it. It was only after we married, or rather during our honeymoon, that each little thing stands out in my memory."

Junshi nodded with a smile as he pictured the past. But this made him feel depressed. Had their happiness gone for good, never to return?

"How about you? What was your happiest time?"

As Xianxian questioned him she stroked his hair, the tip of her bracelet dangling between his eyebrows.

"I don't disagree with you but I can't approve either. For me the first year or, as you say, first month of our marriage was only the start, not the height of our happiness. I wanted to make an ideal woman of you, and that was the start of making my dream come true, so I was buoyed up by hope but didn't achieve real happiness."

"You've often told me that."

Xianxian interrupted him drily. Though when she heard this talk before she had been "buoyed up by hope", she no longer liked being told that he had shaped her according to his ideal.

"But you've never asked me if I succeeded or failed, Xianxian. My dream did come true, but at the same time I failed. That summer in Mt. Mogan I managed to mould you. Remember what we did on the boulder by the Yinlingshan waterfall? You were very shy, but you sat there in only your vest, the way you are now.

Of course that was a little thing, but it proved that I'd managed to shape you, my dream had come true."

He broke off abruptly, taking Xianxian's arm and staring fixedly at her. Her cheeks burned as she thought back to that episode, and she reproached herself for not having felt at the time that such a novel stimulus was so essential. Nowadays. . . .

"My dream came true, only to go up in smoke! My cup of happiness was already full. Before, our road in life was bright but after that darkness mingled with the brightness. Mt. Mogan was the watershed for us. After we came back you gradually changed. Yes, Xianxian, from then on you changed little by little. You changed into yourself, not the ideal woman I wanted to make you. The books I got you to read didn't mean the same to you as they did to me. I don't know why, because I can't believe that one book can have two different interpretations. You've been influenced, Xianxian, by something apart from books, apart from what I've taught you. And so you've destroyed yourself! Destroyed my ideal!"

Junshi had changed colour and closed his eyes. The shattering of his ideal distressed him; the dream-like past added to his depression.

2

At twenty Junshi had high hopes of the future. He commemorated his twentieth year as the time when his father had died leaving him quite a fortune and he had become a free agent. Though only twenty he was no romantic; his father's homilies had ended his youthful

exuberance and made him realistic. By his father's bier he had mapped out his life; with tears for his father in his eyes, he had focussed on his future. Like a traveller planning his journey, he carefully worked out the way to achieve his dream. He wanted to study widely, to find an ideal companion in life, to travel abroad and in the country to investigate local customs, to temper himself to stand hardships and learn self-restraint. In his mid thirties, at the height of his powers, he would have a son and a daughter; then, after forty, he would serve his country and mankind.

Junshi owed these ideals in part to his father. After the failure of the Reform Movement of 1898, his old man had stopped hoping for an official career and concentrated instead on running his business and educating his son. He had passed on to Junshi his theories about national salvation and entrusted this duty to him. Now old, he regretted that in his prime he had been too busy making a living to settle down to a career; he therefore impressed on his son the need to "establish himself in life". He mapped out his future for him and tried to mould him according to his own ideals. He had only half succeeded by the time he died.

Junshi had obviously inherited his father's creative urge. He spent a great deal of time and energy looking for a life-time companion. He had his criteria for an "ideal wife" and used these as a yardstick for potential candidates, deploring the fact that society had produced no "ideal wife" for him. After five or six years his relatives worried about him, his friends looked round for him, but he refused to make up his mind. Finally his "choosiness" became the subject of gossip. When his friends saw him they always asked if he'd settled on

someone, but he just shook his head. One day an old classmate raised the subject with him.

"Junshi, you've been looking all these years for a wife and I, to say nothing of others, must have introduced you to at least two dozen girls. Were none of them up to scratch?"

"They were up to scratch but not ideal."

"Isn't up to scratch ideal? What difference is there? Please explain."

"Of course there's a difference." Junshi smiled. "Up to scratch is just passable. That falls far short of ideal. If I'd just wanted someone up to scratch I needn't have waited for seven years."

"Well then, tell me what you mean by ideal."

His old classmate, thoroughly intrigued, lit a cigarette and put his legs up as he waited to be enlightened.

"By ideal I mean she must have the same disposition and views as mine."

Junshi smiled as he said this.

"No other requirements — no other explanation?"

"No. It's as simple as that."

His old classmate looked disappointed. He persisted:

"Well, you should be able to find someone with the same disposition and views. Seems to me Miss Zhang would suit you fine, and you and Miss Wang ought to see eye to eye. Why did you turn them both down?"

"Miss Zhang's quite cultivated, and Miss Wang has a good disposition. But even putting the two of them together still wouldn't be ideal. Both have certain prejudices — academic prejudices and prejudices about other things."

The other stared at him, baffled.

"By prejudices I mean they go to extremes. Yes,

that's the trouble with most modern young women. For instance, freedom of action is necessary, but they tend to be flighty. They should be broad-minded but they concentrate on outside affairs neglecting their duties at home as wives and mothers. Of course traditional ideas are no good, but unfortunately most of them have new-fangled notions which don't make sense."

"Well, that makes it hard, but surely you can find someone?"

His old classmate spoke gravely, thinking: So his ideal is a woman who's not wholly modern nor traditional.

"But don't make the mistake of thinking I want a girl neither wholly modern nor traditional," Junshi added as if reading his friend's mind. "No, I want someone wholly modern, but one who won't go to dangerous extremes."

"That's difficult. Our chaotic society with all its contradictions can't produce girls like that."

Junshi nodded agreement.

"Better marry a foreigner," his classmate proposed, struck by a new idea. "Most English girls should suit you. That's it, Junshi, find yourself an English girl. Since you're thinking of going to Europe, start looking in London."

"That's one way, but it wouldn't do for me. My ideal wife must have a Chinese background with a cultural heritage of five thousand years — she can't be a foreigner."

"Well, Junshi, you'll probably remain a bachelor all your life. Or you'll have to wait for ten or twenty years, by which time Chinese society may be settled enough to produce your ideal wife."

With this melancholy conclusion his classmate wanted to close the discussion; but Junshi had more to say. Raising one thumb to sketch a half circle in the air he went on earnestly:

"No. I've a new plan. I shall look for uncut jade — that's it, uncut jade which I can carve myself. Yes, since society hasn't produced an ideal wife for me, I mean to create one!"

Junshi's eyes were flashing with determination, but his classmate only smiled. Create a wife? Was he joking? However, this was what Junshi had decided. He had already worked it out: A pure, innocent girl born into a family neither new nor old, even if she hadn't studied but was naturally intelligent could always be trained. And any traditional ways she had could easily be changed.

After more than a year Junshi found his uncut jade — Xianxian his young maternal cousin. He had taken the first step towards attaining his ideal.

Xianxian had her father's intelligence and forthrightness, her mother's gentleness and circumspection. Her father had taught her Chinese, her mother housekeeping. An excellent student who rapidly learned whatever she took up, she was greatly influenced by her surroundings. She was really a fine piece of uncut jade. In merely two years she read all the books Junshi assigned her and gained a higher than average understanding of natural sciences, history, literature, philosophy and modern trends of thought. When she and Junshi visited Mt. Mogan she outshone the other wives and daughters of "high-class Chinese" who were summering there. Her refined behaviour, cultivated speech, extensive knowledge, clear head and liveliness all prov-

ed that Junshi had surpassed himself in moulding her character.

Still, this process had been difficult.

To start with Xianxian had disliked politics and reading newspapers because her father, a talented and unconventional scholar, considered politics dirty, so naturally she hadn't inherited any political acumen from him. Junshi on the other hand paid close attention to politics, believing that men were political animals and that a girl with no understanding of politics fell short of ideal. He himself had studied all the political theorists from Plato to Hobbes and Rousseau, even including Kropotkin, Marx and Lenin. But he held sound, moderate views, never going to extremes. He wanted to inculcate these views in Xianxian. His attitude to women's suffrage was that of President Roosevelt who said that if the majority of women asked for suffrage he'd let them have it. But the "blue stocking" suffragettes in England struck Junshi as extremists.

Like a stern father who wants his son to win fame he urged Xianxian to read political science, to keep abreast of international trends and memorize important names and dates. He asked her to write a daily review of current events in China, which he then corrected for her. After three months' struggle he managed to interest her in politics.

His second difficulty was Xianxian's happy-go-lucky temperament which needless to say she inherited from her father. This was something Junshi hadn't bargained for. He didn't discover this till one beautiful April afternoon half a year after their marriage. During an outing to Longhua that day they sat down to rest under

some peach trees beside the dirt road. Xianxian lifted her face to catch the pink petals fluttering down between her eyebrows, on to her lips and the nape of her neck, and inside her open collar to cling to her breasts. This reminded Xianxian of Junshi's caresses, exciting her as if spring had electrified all her cells, nerves and tiny blood vessels, making her conscious of the slightest touch, the faintest sound, able to remember most insignificant trifles. At the same time countless ideas swirled through her mind and a sweet yet bitter sensation filled her heart. There was no end to what she wanted to say, but not a word could she get out. She just took Junshi's hand and gripped it hard as if this were a form of silent communion.

A ragged drunk, red in the face, with a peach sprig tucked behind one ear, came lurching across the road singing lustily. After shooting a glance at them from his bloodshot eyes he sang even more loudly as he headed west.

"Ha, ha, haha!"

Laughing like a maniac the drunk looked at the corner of the road where a sentry was standing stiff as a wooden puppet. After saying something to him he reeled off to vanish into the peach orchard.

"Ha, ha, haha. . . ."

His laughter as it faded away echoed through the air like the shredding of candy floss. Xianxian relaxed and transferred her gaze from the corner of the road to Junshi's face. On her lips appeared an enigmatic smile.

"A drunk! A drunk roaming in spirit outside the universe!" she exclaimed approvingly. "He's like

Zhuangzi's* Wang Tai whose feet were cut off, or the man who had no toes, or the one with a big tumour — they may look repulsive but their goodness shines through. Did you notice his eyes, Junshi? They showed his utter content. In his eyes all we admire — wealth, rank, fame, power and beauty — fades into insignificance. Because he despises all that. Because to him there's no difference between rich and poor, noble and humble, intelligent and stupid, worthy and worthless, right and wrong, big and small. That's why he's so contented with everything. Dad often says: In his cups a man begins to be 'complete' and 'genuine'. Only today have I really understood that. We who pride ourselves on our intelligence or beauty are just like frogs at the bottom of a well. We're really too feeble for words."

Junshi stared at her in amazement, not answering.

"I remember Dad taught me Zhuangzi when I was eighteen. I was carried away by that part 'Miaogu Shoots an Immortal'. I felt ashamed then of the way I'd been praised for my good looks and intelligence, because I'm really so dreadfully uncouth. Later Dad said Miaogu's shooting at an immortal most likely stood for the primeval spirit transcending creation; still I felt myself unbearably uncouth. It often seems to me that we should look down on everything as if standing on the clouds, so that everything seems level, of the same height. When I've tried to do this for a while I've felt that I really have transcended the world, forgetting my own existence and the existence of others."

Xianxian gazed up as if she could see Miaogu's symbolic figure coolly riding the wind to the other side of the sky.

* Zhuangzi (c. 369-286 B.C.) was a Taoist philosopher.

Junshi was thinking hard. He had only just discovered this dangerous trancendentalist trend in Xianxian. He recalled that not long ago she had read the debate between the Western schools of monism and dualism, and had written this comment: "If you look on others as different, they are as far apart as Chu and Yue.* If you look on others as the same, all creation becomes one. Isn't that what Zhuangzi said?" He also recalled her reading the disputes of different political schools over the function of the state. She had told him with a smile, "They're all of them both right and wrong." He had thought at the time she was joking, now he realized that she based her views on Zhuangzi: she was standing on the clouds to watch the political disputes in different parts of the world. He decided to give top priority to stopping her from taking things too philosophically.

Since then he had induced her to study evolution, Nietzsche and the great materialists. In view of the deplorable result of making her read the teachings of both sides, he now restricted her to one side only. Although opposed himself to the application of materialism to social science, to cure her idealism and nihilism he resorted to this strong materialist medicine.

And finally he had succeeded.

However, another small rectification was needed. For some reason, though Xianxian was unconventional she was shy about showing emotion. The first time they

* A quotation from Zhuangzi. Chu and Yue were two of the Warring States, one in the west the other in the east.

went out together she kept half a foot behind him. If he held her hand in public, she would blush and soon find some pretext to pull it away. Junshi often laughed at this old-fashioned coyness of hers. Under his influence she did become bolder, but still not lively enough for his liking. And in bed she was often passive, which he found dull and insipid. He believed in heredity and feared her bashfulness might make their children timid, so he went all out to change this. Where there's a will there's a way. By the time they visited Mt. Mogan Xianxian had grown lively and uninhibited, able to express her devotion to him in public.

Now the pupil had surpassed her master. In fact sometimes she quite embarrassed Junshi by being so demonstrative and requiring such powerful stimuli.

3

Recalling the last two years as he leaned lazily against the bed-post, Junshi couldn't refrain from thinking bitterly, "You've destroyed yourself! Destroyed my ideal!" The beautiful dream of his twenties was now hazy, misted over. Xianxian was the first to get up. She hopped about the room like a little sparrow, humming a song.

The sunlight had now receded to the back of the sofa. The sound of traffic carried in by the breeze made it clear that it was after nine. Two glasses of hot milk waited quietly, as if smiling, on the table. The big wardrobe mirror reflected its lively mistress. The triple mirror on her dressing-table seemed jealous, as if it alone had the right to reflect her snowy skin.

All the things in the room basking in the May morning sunshine stood lined up in silence to await his orders. They appeared puzzled too by their master's unusual delay in getting up.

The bed gave a soft sigh to complain of having worked overtime.

But Junshi went on staring glumly at the top of the mosquito-net and showed no sign of getting out of bed.

"Are you very tired, Junshi? What's on your mind?" asked Xianxian affectionately.

Sitting on the left armchair she was pulling on a silk stocking. The lower part of her long woollen vest had ridden up slightly, releasing the fragrance of her warm flesh.

Junshi smiled wrily and shook his head in silence.

"Are you still chewing over what I said? Did I annoy you by saying, 'It's you who destroyed your ideal'? Or 'you summoned up a demon but can't control it'. Did that upset you? I was just talking casually, not thinking you'd take it to heart. Silly boy, don't go imagining things. You succeeded. I haven't gone against you. Aren't I going in the direction you mapped out? I may actually be a step ahead of you, but we're going in the same direction."

He made no answer.

"I've done all you asked. Been influenced by you in all my thoughts and actions. Yet you say I've come under someone else's influence. Of course I know you mean Miss Li. But Junshi, why give someone else all the credit; you should be proud of being such a good tutor. You've cured me of my happy-go-lucky ways, made me keen on politics, made me what I am today; but now you disapprove of me. Why, Junshi, silly boy, you're like the Taoist Huang who invoked a devil.

When he chanted his incantations he was only afraid the devil wouldn't come; when it really came he was terrified because it was so vicious, not the devil he had dreamed of."

Xianxian burst out laughing, though she could see that Junshi was glowering. She pulled on her other silk stocking, then went to the bed to take his face in her hands.

"Let's say no more about it," she proposed archly. "Who knows what tomorrow may bring. Tomorrow, no, I ought to say any hour, minute or second now your ideas or mine may change, both of us may change; we may move further apart or we may draw closer together. Who knows? Today's different from yesterday, tomorrow will be different again, and what about after that? We haven't yet dreamed about it; this is today's fashionable trend. But Junshi, you're still clinging to the ideal of your twenties, thinking it holds good for everywhere and all times. That's really ridiculous. Come on, stop giving way to foolish fancies. The past is over and done with, we can discuss the future when it comes, so let's stop daydreaming. We can only grasp the present, only act on our present understanding, Junshi, good boy, Xianxian loves you; let's make it up."

She swiftly pinned him down, her soft firm flesh rubbing against him, her laughter floating out to fill the room. It seemed even the books piled decorously on the desk by the left window could not help feeling flustered. Junshi sensed something forced about her laughter — some hidden grief, regret or reproach. Sure enough, two pearly tears welled up in her lovely eyes, fell by the bridge of his nose, then trickled down to his mouth. As if electrified he clasped her tight and buried his lips in her neck — she had just turned her face away. His feelings were a mixture of sweetness and bitterness, love, resentment and pity. Something like those of a stern father when his prodigal son comes back to kneel at his feet.

But this feeling quickly passed, to be replaced by another.

— Was this what made women such a mystery? So frail? Such sentimentalists? Was this why they seldom developed sound, moderate views but often went too far or not far enough? Did this excitement, tension, hesitation and wretchedness spring from modern thinking? From the confusion and contradictions of their generation? Was this the lassitude, fear and ennui concealed behind active, fervid stimuli?

This reinforced Junshi's conviction that his views were sound and that Xianxian had destroyed herself. For the sake of his ideal and also of Xianxian he must keep up the struggle till the final victory and cure her of those subversive views which only made her wretched. Seeing a ray of hope his courage increased a hundred-fold just as when, ten years ago, he had stood by his father's bier.

He instinctively glanced sideways at Xianxian's face. She was stealing a glance at him too.

She started giggling. Blushed faintly. Her half-closed eyes crinkled in a smile like a charm while the warmth of her flesh was melting him. The enchantress! Symbol of modernism! Junshi began to waver. But reason enabled him to resist temptation, and he knew from experience that this was Xianxian's way of avoiding a scolding. She wasn't going to fool him so easily. He kissed her soft rosy cheek, then told her firmly:

"Xianxian, what you say, like your ideas and actions, is half-baked. We encourage children to be lively,

but don't want them to climb on to grown-ups' heads. Children go on playing till the game breaks up in tears; they have no idea when to stop. Recently you've been growing more and more childish, Xianxian. I got you to take an interest in politics, not expecting you to plunge into real politics, not to say unsound, illicit political movements. For instance nowadays everybody talks about 'politics of the whole people,' but they don't expect to achieve this overnight, they just want everyone to learn that expression. Those who try to put it into practice are fools. But that's the way you've been heading, Xianxian. You don't realize how childish it is, or how dangerous. This morning I had a nightmare — I dreamed about you. . . ."

He had to stop at this point, because Xianxian was giggling uncontrollably. He looked doubtfully, disapprovingly into her eyes.

"Go on."

Though she had suppressed her laughter, it was clear from her quivering breasts that she was still laughing inwardly.

"First tell me what you find funny."

"Nothing. Regarding children — if you really want to hear I'll tell you. Listening to you made me think of a way to satisfy children. You tell an eight-year-old, 'Good boy, when you're ten I promise to buy you that.' But a ten-year-old's told to wait till he's eleven. Always promises for next year. And when the child grows bigger he no longer wants that thing, there's no more trouble. Junshi, don't you agree?"

He nodded reluctantly, suspecting her of being caustic.

"I'd love to hear your dream, but I'm sure it was

very long, as long as your life. Keep it till this evening to tell me in detail. Look, the clock says nine twenty. I haven't washed yet. I've an appointment at ten."

Not waiting for an answer she slipped out of Junshi's arms. Her long vest rode up again, revealing her rosy flesh to confront her husband who had sat up abruptly. Not stopping to straighten her vest she ran through the small door by her dressing-table and slammed it shut.

Junshi sat down in front of Xianxian's desk and leafed through the magazine lying untidily there. The way his wife had run out on him hurt him. He couldn't think what she meant by it. She didn't seem all that set on carrying out her present proposals, nor could she free herself from her old habits; after all she was used to a life of luxury. She didn't seem altogether satisfied either by what she called her activities, because after each action she showed hesitation and anxiety. Thus just now she had said incisively, "The past is done with, don't daydream about the future; we must grasp the present and act according to our present understanding." But her hysterical laughter hid unhappiness and tears. He couldn't make her out. Had her attitude to him changed? She still treated him as fondly as ever. If it hadn't changed, at least she no longer wanted him to concern himself with her affairs and had lost patience with his criticisms. Just now she hadn't even wanted to hear his dream.

Ah, he thought, a woman's heart is a mystery.

A mystery? Yes, especially in Xianxian's case. She was a complex character. He carefully analysed the

Xianxian of today, then considered the process by which he had moulded her.

Memories long smothered by dust surfaced one by one; random, disconnected views coalesced bit by bit, finally forcing him to admit that what he had called creation was actually sabotage. And his sabotage tactics had taken root in Xianxian's heart. Had sabotaged her happy acceptance of fate and put materialism in its place; had sabotaged her unconventional aversion to politics, so that now she was a prey to radical views. Had sabotaged her shyness and refinement, so that she had grown sensual and demanded strong stimuli. Apparently she had never related to his thinking. She was easily influenced by her surroundings, yet his views had failed to influence her in the least. When he thought he had succeeded in moulding her, he had just deceived himself. He had failed from the start, not succeeded for one moment. He had thought their honeymoon on Mt. Mogan a success, but that was nonsense. He had worked all this time for nothing.

He recalled Xianxian's remark, "It's you who destroyed your ideal." He had to admit she was right. Miss Li was not to blame.

How could he have been such a fool! He had thought he could step by step realize his dream, whereas he now knew he had step by step destroyed it. Had strained every nerve to create an ideal wife, only to find her nothing of the kind.

— Our chaotic society with all its contradictions can never produce an ideal character.

His old classmate's observation flashed to his mind. He loathed this society. Its chaos and contradictions

had sabotaged his ideal. Its atmosphere made it impossible to do anything well. He was in utter despair.

Running water sounded from behind the small door by her dressing-table, telling him that his charming, intelligent young wife was taking a bath.

Junshi turned involuntarily towards that door, distracted by the plash of water. Suddenly a head poked out of the big wardrobe mirror. Whirling round he saw Amah Wang peeping in from the bedroom door which had opened a crack. At sight of Junshi sitting there blankly, still in his pyjamas, she realized this was no time to go in.

A new idea struck Junshi.

Why despair? Though a chaotic, contradictory society was said to be unable to produce moderates with sound ideas, wasn't he living in this society too? How had he been produced? Clearly, society's power over individuals wasn't absolute.

Why should he lose confidence? His efforts over the last two years might have been wasted, but only because he'd been too busy undermining Xianxian to inculcate his own ideas into her. Couldn't he have another try to remould her, to win her back? Sure! Before, he'd used such strong antidotes against her happy-go-lucky and unconventional ways that he'd made her delirious. Well, now he'd use mild healthy ideas to restore her to health. There was hope. While there's life there's hope! All he had to do was recognize his past mistake.

Junshi felt more optimistic than he had for two weeks. This enabled him to make a sober appraisal of his attitude to Xianxian recently. His cutting re-

marks, he saw now, had been a mistake, had put her back up. And his recent conservative views, due to the circumstances, were no good either, making Xianxian feel that he was really regressing. It had been a mistake too, because of his resentment, to refuse to go to the meetings she attended. He ought to go with her, then voice his dispassionate disapproval to help her see the error of her ways.

Feeling more and more sure of himself, Junshi kept looking at the bathroom door. His new plan worked out, he was waiting for Xianxian's return to try it out on her. He felt as keyed up as a student waiting for an examination paper.

The bedroom door softly opened again. Amah Wang slowly poked in her head, her bright black eyes scanning the room. She tiptoed in to gather up Xianxian's clothes heaped on the sofa, then tiptoed out.

Junshi went on ruminating, reassessing what Xianxian had said. Two sentences he had overlooked now demanded his attention.

— Aren't I going in the direction you mapped out? I may be a step ahead of you, but we're both going in the same direction.

"A step ahead of you." He thought that over. Apparently Xianxian admitted that she'd been influenced by him and followed him, but just now had outstripped him. He abruptly recalled that someone else — most likely Miss Li — had said something similar, implying that he had been Xianxian's guide but had stopped to rest halfway while she had gone on ahead. Was that really the case? Junshi thought too highly of himself to admit it. Refused to believe that he was a spineless fellow who would give up halfway. He reflected: If

he was really a middle-of-the-roader, that was because he'd been to one edge of the road, seen something wrong with it and come back to the middle. At all events Xianxian had clearly been influenced by him, as she had admitted as much to her best friend. Yet he had negated that in his recent conclusion and believed that he had used someone else's potent medicine to destroy the original Xianxian and now would have to start all over again.

He was really confused. He believed his conclusion had been quite correct, yet lacked reasons to debunk Xianxian's declaration. Though still buoyed up by optimism he felt rather dubious. He encouraged himself by saying, "I must first solve this riddle; otherwise I won't know how to set to work." But his brain congested by all that hard thinking had run out of inspiration.

The bedroom door opened again. Once more Amah Wang came in, peered round, went to the dressing-table and from one drawer took out a pair of Xianxian's brown leather shoes which she carried off.

Junshi saw Amah Wang come in then go out, and stared for a minute at the bedroom door. Then his glance strayed over Xianxian's desk, finally coming to rest on the ivory rabbit. He picked it up and noticed the word "husband" scratched out by a knife. But this didn't strike him as strange. He remembered Xianxian saying there was something revoltingly traditional about "husband", inevitably suggesting a patriarch, and it should be changed to "sweetheart". So here, too, it was taboo! He couldn't help smiling over her childishness. That made him wonder why she hadn't come out yet.

She'd been gone so long, and it was quite a time since he'd heard the plash of water. He listened carefully. There was no sound from the bathroom. Could she have dozed off in the tub?

Junshi walked to the dressing-table, convinced that Xianxian must be asleep in the tub. He was about to turn the porcelain door-knob when the door suddenly opened. Out came someone carrying towels and a dressing-gown.

Not Xianxian but Amah Wang.

"Oh . . . it's you."

Junshi started. Then at once understood. The bathroom door to the outer room was wide open: Xianxian must have gone downstairs. His wife — his sweetheart — had sneaked away like a rebel from a tailing detective! Now he understood why Amah Wang had come in twice to fetch her clothes and shoes. Why should his wife play such a trick on him?

Seeing Junshi's look of displeasure Amah Wang explained:

"The young mistress finished her bath long ago. Told me to clean the tub."

Junshi's ears were buzzing too much to hear what she said. He recalled his ominous dream. Scented disaster. His effervescent warmth turned suddenly cold. This was a blow to his pride. His heart was pounding a warning.

"Is your mistress downstairs?"

Amah Wang detected his tension from his voice.

"She's gone out. Told me to tell you, sir, she's gone on ahead, she wants you to catch up. And she said if you can't catch up with her she won't wait."

"Oh. . . ."

A moment later a strangled sob burst from Junshi's throat. The little ivory rabbit obsessed him again. By degrees it grew larger and took human shape, gazing at him disdainfully with its pink eyes. He had a hazy notion that it was Xianxian. Finally it vanished, eyes and all. Only the scratches on the word "husband" on its white belly swayed more clearly than ever before him.

February 23, 1928

Translated by Gladys Yang

Mao Dun, Master Craftsman of Modern Chinese Literature

Fan Jun

LITERARY innovation in modern China has been closely linked with the awakening of the Chinese nation epitomized in the May 4th Movement of 1919, which put an end to the dominance of classical language and tradition and heralded the advent of modernism. Modern literature was thus the product of a growing ideological awareness of modern ideas about democracy, socialism and the role of literature itself. The corruption permeating society and the danger the nation faced, as well as the revolutionary fervour to which these gave rise and which had its own roots in the May 4th Movement too, occupied the attention of the majority of writers, who consciously or unconsciously joined the revolutionary struggle by taking up their pens to analyse social reality. It was against this socio-historical background that the revolution began to influence literature directly and profoundly and determine the direction in which it would develop, conferring on it a historical character foreign to its precursors. Mao Dun, a versatile talent, was active during this process.

Fan Jun, 55, born in Zhejiang, is a research fellow in the Literature Research Institute of the Academy of Social Sciences in Beijing.

Mao Dun, whose real name was Shen Yanbing, used this pen-name when he began writing in the late 1920s. He was well known both nationally and internationally as a writer, but was at the same time a social activist. One of the earliest members of the Chinese Communist Party, he began revolutionary work in the mid-1920s and continued to take an active part in social and political struggle throughout his life. But it was literature which he made his career, one in which he achieved splendid things. National liberation and social progress were the constant goal of his writing. In him were combined the social activist and the man of letters, the writer and the revolutionary. It is nonetheless in the establishment and development of modern Chinese literature that his contributions were greatest and where his far-reaching influence can be felt today even after his death. He was truly one of the great men of modern Chinese literature.

I

When Mao Dun was born on July 4, 1896 in Tongxiang, Zhejiang, the last feudal dynasty, the Manchu Qing empire, was on the verge of collapse, and the people of China were seeking liberation and a way to change their society. His home was on the southeast coast close to Shanghai, in that economically and culturally developed area where advanced science and thought were first introduced from Japan and the West. His father was a doctor who sympathized with the doomed Reform Movement of 1898, and consequently Mao Dun grew up in a relatively free and progressive atmosphere, reading books that would never have found their way into

the hands of a child in a feudal family, among them popular novels whose wealth of social content at once instilled in him a love of literature and a democratic consciousness. His political zeal was further fired by the Revolution of 1911, which finally toppled the ailing dynasty, and he began to busy himself with propaganda work; a protest against the autocratic nature of his middle school got him expelled.

In 1916, as the ideals of the May 4th Movement were crystallizing at last, Mao Dun graduated from the preparatory course at Beijing University, went to work for the Commercial Press and began to write. He formed eclectic intellectual habits at these two institutions, which despite being tightly controlled by conservative interests were respected as disseminators of advanced ideas in both science and politics.

His early writing was aimed predominantly at the young and preoccupied with the nature of ideological enlightenment, so that when Hu Shi, Chen Duxiu and Lu Xun began to promote the literary revolution through the columns of their magazine *New Youth*, they found in the young Mao Dun a ready response. In January 1920, he began to experiment with literary innovation as editor of the "New Trends in Fiction" feature of the magazine *Short Story Monthly*, which by the end of the year he had taken over and transformed thoroughly. From this he went on to join with Zhou Zuoren, Ye Shengtao, Zheng Zhenduo and others in founding the Literary Research Society to put his ideas into practice by promoting realistic literature that mirrored life. He was not only the society's active organizer but also the elaborator of the theory it stood for. His management and advocacy gave *Short Story Monthly* and the Lit-

erary Research Society alike a modern flavour all their own which destined them to be enormously influential.

His articles from these years reveal a keen concern for the freedom of youth and the liberation of women. It was after the 1920s that he began to be drawn to Marxist theory and the ideals of the Russian Revolution, which were just then becoming known in China, and this led him to direct involvement with the Chinese communist movement. He was never exclusively concerned with literature. The outbreak of the First Revolutionary Civil War (1924-27) rapidly disillusioned him with the "enlightenment" of the early post-May-4th literature, and he began to call for "great changes". As one of the first writers to combine proletarian Marxism with literature, he helped to make the step from literary revolution to revolutionary literature. In 1930, he joined the China League of Left-wing Writers, which for a time he led in this spirit during what many historians have called the "red 30s". He added lustre to that turbulent decade with a phenomenal output of original writing and criticism, working in close association with Lu Xun and Qu Qiubai. His novel *Midnight* was universally regarded as a prime example of revolutionary literature and was enthusiastically received by writers themselves and the reading public, soon achieving international status with translations into English, Russian and German.

In 1937, the War of Resistance Against Japan broke out, which was destined to last for eight years and be followed by another three years of the War of Liberation, a turbulent period during which Mao Dun was constantly on the move from place to place in an attempt to evade the ravages of the invaders as well as the per-

secution of the Kuomintang government. He lived in Urumqi, Yan'an, Guangzhou, Hongkong, Wuhan, Changsha, Guilin and Chongqing, and as a council member of the All-China Federation of Writers and Artists for Resistance Against the Enemy he continued his work of writing, criticism and translation, besides editing literary journals — *Literary Front* was one of the most important magazines of the war of resistance — and the literary supplements of several newspapers.

With the death of Lu Xun in 1936, Mao Dun and Guo Moruo became the most prestigious and influential writers in China. Mao Dun devoted himself to the twin tasks of making literature contribute to national liberation and winning acceptability and popularity for it with the public at large whilst at the same time exploring the theoretical and creative possibilities of a distinctively Chinese literature.

The Yan'an Forum on Literature and Art, held in 1942, encouraged much new writing in the liberated areas; full of admiration for the new literature, Mao Dun embodied its principles in his own work in the Kuomintang-controlled areas, extending his endeavours beyond the literary field into the forefront of the ideological struggle for national freedom and democracy against world fascism.

For a long period after the founding of the People's Republic of China in 1949, Mao Dun was a leading figure in government cultural institutions and in other literary and artistic bodies, interesting himself particularly in cultural exchanges with foreign countries and the defence of world peace. At the same time he kept up his theoretical work and literary criticism, writing voluminously on new writers. His contribution to the

world-wide debate on socialist realism of the late 1950s was *Notes of a Night Reader*, a summary of world literature down to modern times upholding realistic writing and the socialist path.

During the "cultural revolution" Mao Dun, like any other honest writer, was persecuted into silence. He was over eighty by the time the storm passed, and began to concentrate on his memoirs, which when finished ran to tens of thousands of words, an invaluable document for the study of his life and work and the political, literary and social history of modern China, besides reviving the tradition of literary memoirs, which had been in abeyance for many years.

Mao Dun died in Beijing on March 27, 1981. On his deathbed he donated his royalties to establish an award for novels to encourage young writers.

2

Mao Dun's greatest achievement was his original writing. His first novel, *Disillusion*, created a sensation in the literary world, but unwilling to restrict himself to a self-made mould, he sought painstakingly for "a new method of expression which better fits the temper of the times".

He wrote altogether seven novels, six novellas, over fifty short stories, one play and ten collections of essays, through which he wanted to "describe the social phenomena of China on a grand scale" and "record some aspects of the heroic drama" of modern Chinese history. In this he succeeded.

His novel *Frosted Leaves Are as Red as Flowers in February* paints a picture of Chinese society from 1911

to 1919, presenting the rise of the young revolution. His long novel *Rainbow* reflects the stormy period from the May 4th Movement to the mid-1920s, while the *Canker* trilogy — *Disillusion, Vacillation* and *The Search* — records the First Revolutionary Civil War from its origins to its failure. *Midnight*, "The Shop of the Lin Family" and "Spring Silkworms" show urban and rural class struggle during the Second Revolutionary Civil War and the growing threat to the nation, strikingly reflecting the life-and-death struggle between opposed social forces.

The Story of the First Stage, Manning the Post and *Training* are stirring works that mobilized the nation for the war of resistance, whereas *Decay* and *Before and After the Qingming Festival* expose the darkness of Kuomintang rule after that war reached its stalemate. His stories from the late 1940s reflect the spectrum of tendencies on the eve of the national victory of the War of Liberation. Taken together, these works form a historical picture of the changes in Chinese society throughout the first half of the twentieth century.

If one work must be singled out, it is surely *Midnight*, set in semi-colonial Shanghai, which with its grand design summarizes the plight of China in the 1930s and the ineluctable failure of capitalism there.

Mao Dun attributed his popularity in part to his willingness to tackle "grand themes which others hesitate to write about" and to the centrality in his work of relationships between and among the people, whereby characters are portrayed in terms of the sum total of human relationships in society.

His broad social palette was unusual among contemporary writers. Perhaps his most successful charac-

ters are capitalists, industrialists, businessmen and the educated young women known as "women of the times". He is as at home with the widest of themes and the most intimate of details and never lapses into superficiality, describing for instance the love of a boy and a dog in "Liena and Jidi" as sincerely as he would the fate of a nation. His essays, commentaries and lyrics, too, range from gentle poeticality to stirring calls for revolution and hopeful visions of the future with uniformly brilliant versatility.

3

At the same time as being a writer, Mao Dun was a literary theorist and critic who spent much more time on these pursuits than on fiction throughout his sixty-year career. Literary criticism played a great role in establishing the new literature after the May 4th Movement, and Mao Dun was a path-breaker in this regard.

Modern Chinese literature needed extrication from traditional Confucian restrictions and resistance to the temptation of art for art's sake; there was a genuine desire for literature that would reflect social reality and the sufferings of the nation. Hence among the many divergent trends which were pursued at the time, the one which eventually took root and developed was realism. This was a feature of articles in *New Youth*, a central tenet of the Literary Research Society's call for "literature for the people", and a point repeatedly stressed by Mao Dun himself from the very beginning. Literature must show concern for the people; literature must portray the people and have the ability to guide

them. The time was ripe for such ideas, and they rapidly caught on. Mao Dun's stand on revolutionary literature, people's literature and socialist literature never wavered, and in this he can be taken as representative of the mainstream of thought on the subject throughout the period during which he was active.

However, being the experienced artist that he was, Mao Dun did not neglect literature's aesthetic role at the same time as he was stressing its social function. "Literature", he wrote in his first article on literary innovation, "is the product of ideology — there is nothing wrong with this. But the constitution of literature relies entirely on art". Although a steadfast proponent of realism whose ideas stemmed from 19th-century realist critical theory, he was not blinded to the limitations of early realism nor prevented from deriving nourishment from other literary trends like romanticism and more advanced realism, especially factors in them which strengthened the function of realism as a reflection of reality. This flexible attitude to realism is instanced in his enthusiasm for Soviet writing in the wake of the October Revolution, which he said, "presents faithfully all aspects of this great and memorable age." Mao Dun's mind was open and abreast of the trends.

A major part of his theoretical work was literary criticism, wherein he proceeded with keen observation and profound knowledge to analyse a writer's work ideologically and artistically in the context of the movement and the history of literature. He was often the first to discover new writers, new works and new trends, grasping their character and appraising them objectively with a foresight that demonstrated his sagacity as a literary historian.

He established himself during the early 1920s as the chief literary critic in the Literary Research Society by a series of articles on new books. He was the first fully to understand and appreciate Lu Xun and was warm in his praise of that writer's "My Old Home" and "The True Story of Ah Q" immediately they came out. When Lu Xun published *Call to Arms,* Mao Dun was quick to point out that the book laid a solid foundation for the modern Chinese short story. Mao Dun's work on Lu Xun is a mine of information for the study of that writer.

"We desperately need," wrote Mao Dun in 1936, "earnest and down-to-earth critics, who must firstly know the actual needs, secondly study and discuss more often the actual problems in creative writing and thirdly endeavour to learn from life."

Mao Dun's contribution to literary criticism is on a par with his original writing but has been neglected in the past. It is only in recent years that greater scholarly attention has been paid to his influence as a critic.

4

With great zeal Mao Dun also studied, wrote about and translated foreign literature and made annotated selections from the Chinese classics.

He translated from 1916 on, specializing in Russian and other Eastern European literature, though he is believed to have translated over thirty years works by at least sixty writers from twenty-five countries, beginning with some two hundred short pieces which appeared in *Short Story Monthly* in the first five years of the 1920s.

In a short period in the late twenties and early thirties he wrote ten books on foreign literature, including *The European War and Literature, Modern Literature, Six European Writers, An Outline of Western Literature* and *Famous Literary Works of the World.*

In 1934, he and Lu Xun founded *Translation* magazine, which carried translations of foreign literature and was the precursor of the present-day *World Literature.* After the founding of the People's Republic he edited *Chinese Literature.* In the study and translation of foreign literature he was also a pioneer.

Although Mao Dun spent less energy on classical Chinese literature than on foreign literature, his annotations are particularly useful for the young beginner. Of especial note is his research into Chinese mythology, which stands alongside Lu Xun's study of Chinese fiction and Zheng Zhenduo's study of Chinese popular literature as an academically valuable breakthrough in a branch of learning.

"We believe," he wrote early on, "that Western and classical Chinese literature can help us create the new Chinese literature. . . . We want to use the old literature as material for our study, investigate its characteristics and combine them with those of Western literature to create a literature of our own." Elsewhere he says, "Our purpose in writing about Western literature is to familiarize the reader with Western writing and art but also with modern ideas from the rest of the world, and this purpose deserves careful attention."

Mao Dun was one of the most outstanding writers of 20th-century China, and his influence has been immense. During a writing career of over sixty years he

produced a wealth of literary works which have inscribed his name indelibly in the modern literary history of his country.

Translated by Niu Jin

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